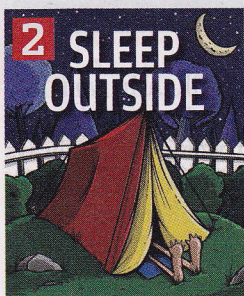




1

Break in a baseball glove

Mets third baseman David Wright's mitt fits, well, like a glove. If you want yours to be the same way, you need to do three things: soften the leather, form the pocket, and play catch. Rub a small dollop of shaving cream, Vaseline, or saddle soap on the leather. Don't soak it or the leather will deteriorate. "When I was a kid, I would stick a ball in the glove and tie it together," says Wright. "But I've always found that just playing catch is the best way to work in a new glove."



3 Start a collection

Trading cards aren't the *only* sports collectible. Start hanging on to scorecards, programs, or ticket stubs. And if you have some shelf space to fill, it'd be fun to see what kind of wacky bobbleheads you can find!



4 THROW A FRISBEE FOREHAND

It's natural to throw a Frisbee backhanded. But it's essential to know how to flick the disc in the game of Ultimate Frisbee. Here's how.

STEP 1: Hold the Frisbee by the rim with your throwing hand, putting your thumb on top of the disc and your other fingers curled in a fist below it. Next, spread your index and middle fingers wide against the bottom of the Frisbee. Your middle finger should be touching the inside of the rim and your index finger extended, making a V-shape on the underside of the disc. Your ring finger and pinkie should stay tucked against the outer edge of the Frisbee.

STEP 2: Stand with your feet shoulder-width apart and facing your target. Hold the Frisbee next to you and angled slightly toward the ground. As you bring the disc back, your elbow should point toward the receiver.

STEP 3: Shift your weight toward your target and swing your arm forward, pivoting at the elbow. Release the disc with a snap of the wrist.



Fun activities to tackle o

5 Catch (and release) a fish

Grab your fishing pole, attach the bait, and cast away. You'll feel a few light tugs on the line and then the struggle begins! Few outdoor activities are more exciting than reeling in a big, leaping catch. You'll need to be patient before you get a bite, but it's worth the wait. Remember to practice catch-and-release fishing, too. If you're not going to eat your catch, snap a quick photo and return the fish to its home.



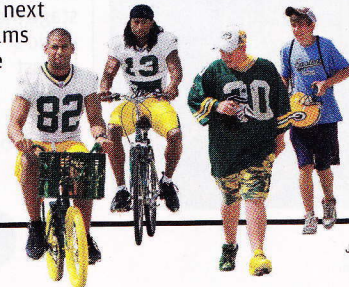
GO THINGS MUST DO SUMMER

to tackle once school's out

BY PHIL BENCOMO AND MAREN KASSELIK

6 Visit an NFL training camp

There's no better way to get up close and personal with NFL players than at training camp. Watch your favorite players and top draft picks prepare for the season, and try to get autographs after practices. The Green Bay Packers even have a tradition in which their players ride young fans' bikes to practice while the bike owners walk next to them. Most teams open camp in late July. Visit NFL.com/trainingcamp for more information.



7 GO FLY A KITE

8 Grip it and rip it

Golf is not just for old people with ugly pants. Check out The First Tee (thefirsttee.org) to find a program in your area and find out how fun golf can be. And with Callaway's XJ Junior clubs, you can now use woods and irons made specially for kids.



9 Have a cannonball contest

May the biggest splash win. Poolside sunbathers, beware!

10 BUILD A SAND STADIUM

If you're sick of making sand castles, try your hand at a sand stadium. Model it after your favorite — will it have Boston's leftfield Green Monster, San Francisco's rightfield splash landing, or Oakland's enormous foul territory?



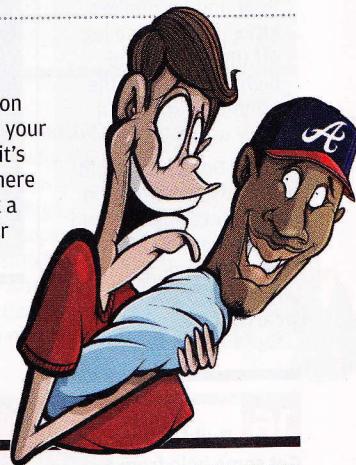
RACE A GO-KART

12 Donate your old sports equipment

You may have outgrown those shin guards or upgraded to a titanium bat, but other kids can still use your old equipment. Sports Gift (www.sportsgift.org) is a nonprofit organization that supplies used gear to children throughout the world. Just drop off your stuff at one of their pickup spots or ship it to them.

13 Adopt a rookie

It's easy to say that LeBron James or Albert Pujols is your favorite player now, but it's cooler to say you were there from the beginning. Pick a rookie and become his or her biggest fan this summer. When Braves rightfielder Jason Heyward becomes the next Hank Aaron, you can tell your friends you saw it coming.



14 MAKE FIVE FREE THROWS IN A ROW

Larry Stewart, general manager of basketball at the Chicago Bulls Sox Training Academy, teaches students the B.E.E.F method. Here's what it stands for.

BALANCE Stand with your feet shoulder-width apart. If you're righthanded, put your right foot in front and slightly bend your knees.

ELBOW Don't let your right elbow flare out, and keep your arm in line with your body. When you bring the ball up to shoot, your elbow should be lined up with your foot.

EYES Focus on the front of the rim. Find the front two eyelets that hold up the net and aim to shoot just over them.

FOLLOW THROUGH Raise the ball up to a comfortable shooting pocket, near the top of your shoulder, and shoot. Snap your wrist and, with your arm up high, "reach into the cookie jar," says Stewart.



15

DO A HANDSTAND FOR FIVE SECONDS

STEP 1: Strengthen your upper body. Luan Plazek of USA Gymnastics recommends building arm strength through pushups, chin-ups, or rope climbing.

STEP 2: Once your upper body is fit enough, put your hands on the floor and try donkey kicks – lifting one leg off the ground and high-kicking with the other to launch your body upright.

STEP 3: Donkey kick into a handstand against a wall. Once you can hold it for five seconds away from the wall, you're ready to graduate to cartwheels.

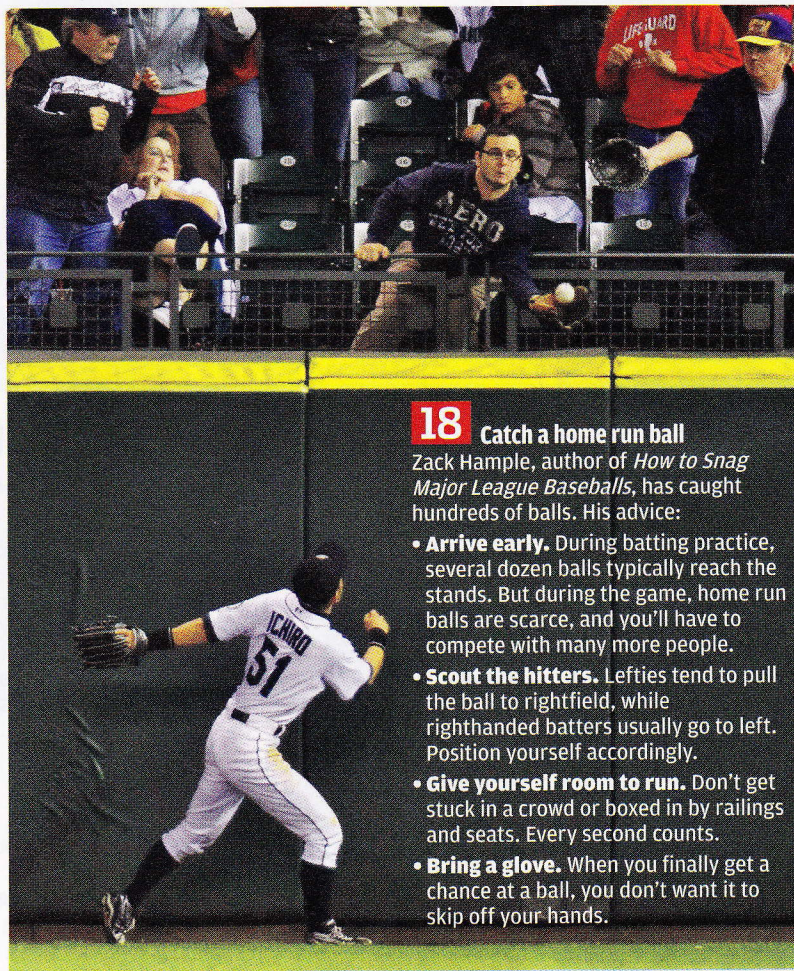
16 Build a ramp

Get some help from a parent and upgrade your skateboard or bike jumps and curb hops with a homemade ramp. FUEL TV's *Built to Shred* host Jeff King says you'll need pallets (portable wooden platforms used to store and transport goods on a forklift), plywood, strong sheet metal, and your parents' circular saw and drill. All you have to do is raise your pallet to your desired height by putting dirt, rocks, or other scrap wood underneath it. Then ask a parent to help you screw the plywood onto the pallet frame and attach the sheet metal to the bottom so you have a smooth transition.



17 Predict the future

Which ball club will win the World Series? Will Joe Mauer take home another MVP trophy? And which teams will meet in the Super Bowl? Write down your best guesses to any questions you choose. Have your friends do the same, and then compare your predictions at the end of the year.



18 Catch a home run ball

Zack Hamble, author of *How to Snag Major League Baseballs*, has caught hundreds of balls. His advice:

- **Arrive early.** During batting practice, several dozen balls typically reach the stands. But during the game, home run balls are scarce, and you'll have to compete with many more people.
- **Scout the hitters.** Lefties tend to pull the ball to rightfield, while righthanded batters usually go to left. Position yourself accordingly.
- **Give yourself room to run.** Don't get stuck in a crowd or boxed in by railings and seats. Every second counts.
- **Bring a glove.** When you finally get a chance at a ball, you don't want it to skip off your hands.

19

SAVE THE PLANET

Helping the environment may be the most rewarding thing you can do. It doesn't have to be complicated. For example, you can pick up and throw away trash in your neighborhood. Grab a few friends and make it into a game.

20

Ride a roller coaster

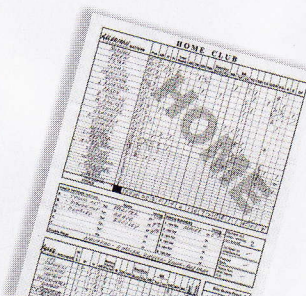
A win on the field is a great way to get blood rushing through your veins, but nothing pumps adrenaline as well (or as quickly) as a sudden drop on a roller coaster. See if you can conquer the tallest ride at a local fair or amusement park. Are you brave enough to do it with your eyes open and hands in the air?



21

Learn to keep score in baseball

Filling out a scorecard is one of baseball's great traditions. By keeping track of every play, you'll feel more involved in the game. Search "keeping score" on MLB.com to learn the basics.



22

Sit in a cool movie theater

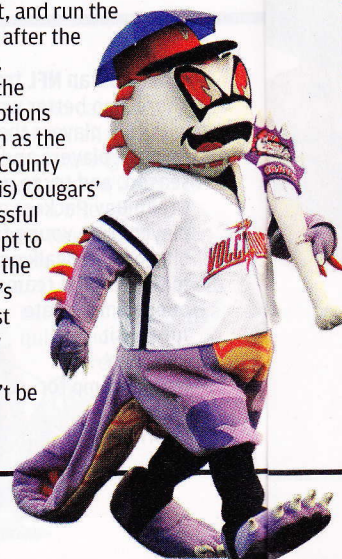
Sometimes the best escape from a hot summer day is an air-conditioned movie theater. Check out *The Karate Kid* (in theaters on June 11) starring Jackie Chan and Jaden Smith (right), or the animated 3-D comedy *Despicable Me* (July 9).



23

Go to a minor league baseball game

Stadiums in the minors are the most kid-friendly venues around. Sure, you can see future major league stars, but it's also a chance to goof around with the mascot, snag a free T-shirt, and run the bases after the game. Plus, the promotions – such as the Kane County (Illinois) Cougars' successful attempt to stage the world's largest pillow fight – can't be beat.



50 THINGS TO DO THIS SUMMER



24 Create a touchdown dance

Start from scratch or combine the classics into a dance of your own. What does a moon-walking robot look like? Try it and find out. Leave the props to Cincinnati Bengals receiver Chad Ochocinco, though. Keep it simple and remember: You've got to score before you can dance.



25 Take a great sports photo

Don't have a fancy camera? A simple point-and-shoot, plus a few tips from *SPORTS ILLUSTRATED* photographer Robert Beck, are all you need.

• **Pick a sport that you and your friends enjoy.** Then use your pals as subjects. You could shoot at a major league game, but you'll get much closer to the action at the neighborhood diamond.

• **Start small.** Even the pros had to begin somewhere, so work on the basics, says Beck. Try not to shoot into the sun, find cool angles (such as from the ground up), and pick simple backgrounds.



27 RUN FASTER

Before you can leave your friends in the dust, you must learn the right technique, says Dave Tebitor, a coach at Velocity Sports Performance. Practice with wall drills, which simulate your starting steps. Lean forward and hold yourself against a wall at a 45-degree angle to the floor. Quickly pump your legs up and down, landing on the balls of your feet.

28 Memorize the uniform numbers of every player on your favorite team

Everyone knows that Tom Brady wears number 12 and Derek Jeter is 2. Only die-hard fans know the numbers for Patriots long snapper Jake Ingram (47) and Yankees backup catcher Francisco Cervelli (29). See if you can learn the digits for every player on your team.

29 JUGGLE A SOCCER BALL

Real Salt Lake midfielder Kyle Beckerman says the best way to hone your ball control is by juggling. Here's how to become a master juggler:

STEP 1: Starting with the ball in your hands, drop it above your right foot and kick it to chest-height off your shoelaces.

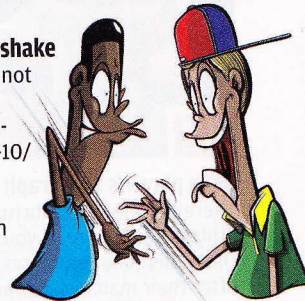
STEP 2: Alternate kicks. After you've kicked the ball with your right foot, catch it and then drop it and kick with your left.

STEP 3: Make fewer catches. Follow the motion: right, left, catch; right, left, right, catch.

KYLE'S AROUND THE WORLD CHALLENGE: "Once you can get 20 juggles in a row, it's time to bump it up," he says. "Go right foot to right thigh to right shoulder to head to left shoulder to left thigh to left foot, back up and back around."

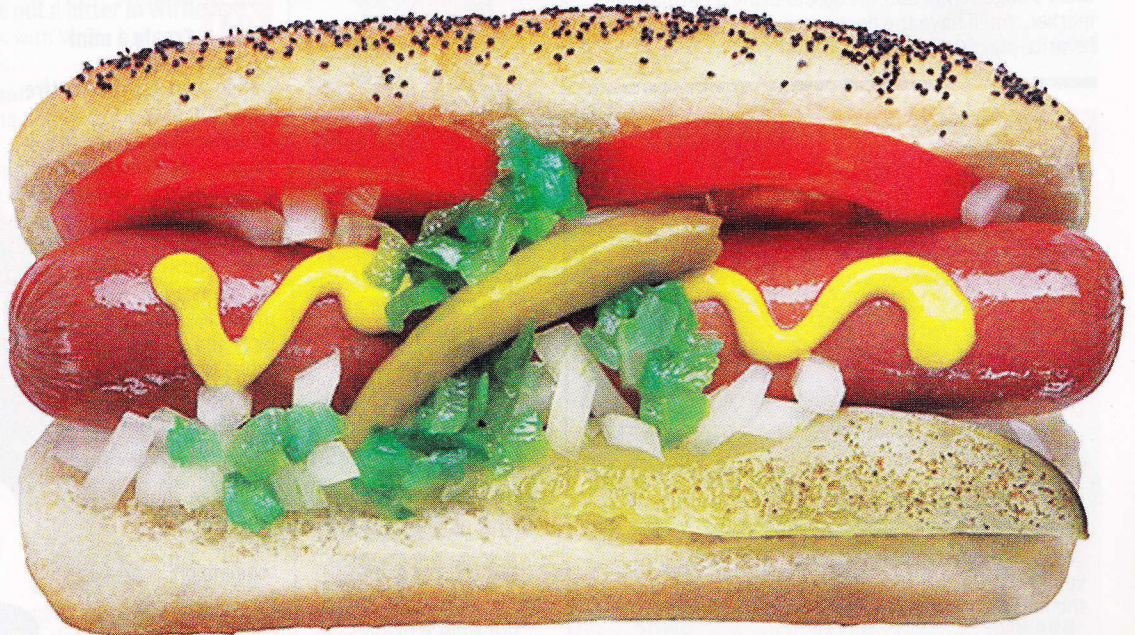
30 Invent your own handshake

The high-five is great, but why not spice it up a bit? Put your own spin on things with, say, a high-five/low-five/behind-the-back-10/double-fist-bump-explosion/shoulder-smack combo. And while you're at it, come up with a special shake for each of your friends.



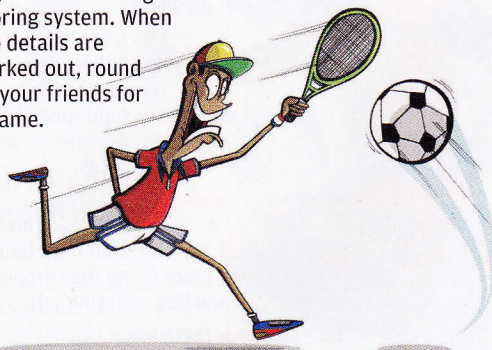
26 Make a Chicago-style hot dog

Served on a poppy seed bun, a Chicago dog is boiled in water (not grilled) and topped with tomato wedges, a kosher pickle spear, chopped onions, sport peppers, yellow mustard, neon-green relish, and a dash of celery salt. No ketchup is allowed. If you don't have plans to visit a Chicago ballpark anytime soon, try making this meal-in-a-bun at home.



31 Invent a new sport

If you love two sports, why not combine them into a supersport? Use a racket to blast a tennis ball out of the park in tennis baseball, or your feet to ace a serve in soccer tennis. See how many sports you can mash together. Don't forget to invent a scoring system. When the details are worked out, round up your friends for a game.



32 Get a player's autograph

There's plenty of opportunities to get your favorite athlete's signature. If you can make it out to the U.S. Open this summer, tennis players often sign autographs after their matches. In baseball, arrive to a game early enough to catch batting practice. Hang out behind your team's dugout and don't forget to bring a permanent marker. You'll have the best success if you wear your favorite player's jersey or bring a homemade sign.

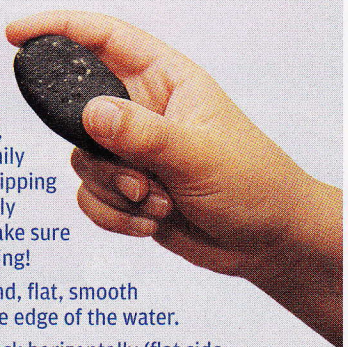
33 SKIP A ROCK

Next time you're at a lake or pond, impress your family and friends by skipping a rock. It's actually pretty simple. Make sure nobody's swimming!

STEP 1: Find a round, flat, smooth rock and go to the edge of the water.

STEP 2: Hold the rock horizontally (flat side down), curling your index finger around its edge.

STEP 3: Use a sidearm motion to throw it low and parallel to the water's surface by snapping only your wrist — like a forehand Frisbee toss. Count the number of times the rock skips.



34 Snowboard in the summer

At High Cascade summer camps in northern Oregon (www.highcascade.com), you can go to a sleep-away camp where you can shred on the glacier peak of Mt. Hood for a week. And if you get sick of boarding, there are skate ramps, trampolines, arts and crafts, and mountain bikes at home base. For more options, check out Windells Camp (www.windells.com) or Whistler Summer Snowboard Camp (www.whistlersnowboardcamps.com).



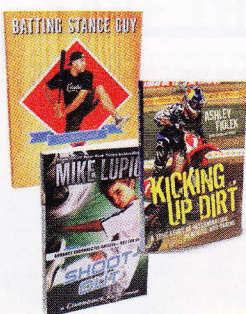
35 Read a great book

There's no better time than summer to curl up with a good book. We recommend these three:

Batting Stance Guy
by Gar Ryness and Caleb Dewart

Shoot-Out
by Mike Lupica

Kicking Up Dirt
by Ashley Fiolek



36 RIDE A BIKE WITH NO HANDS

But wear a helmet.

37

Dunk a basketball

You don't need a trampoline or an adjustable outdoor hoop to dunk. Buy a Nerf basketball hoop that connects to your bedroom or closet door for less than \$10 at a sporting goods store. With a little practice you can perform a reverse-360 degree tomahawk jam leaping off your bed.

38 Figure out your on-base percentage

How often do you get on base when you step in the batter's box? To calculate your on-base percentage (OBP), add up your hits, walks, and hit by pitches. Then divide that number by your total number of at bats, walks, sacrifices, and hit by pitches. In math speak it looks like this:

$$OBP = (H + BB + HBP) / (AB + BB + SF + HBP)$$

39 Dribble a basketball between your legs

Trip up your defender with ankle-breaking moves on the court. Once you master dribbling with your shooting hand, try it with your weaker hand. After you master that, practice dribbling figure eights around your legs. Before the summer ends you'll be the Rajon Rondo of your neighborhood.

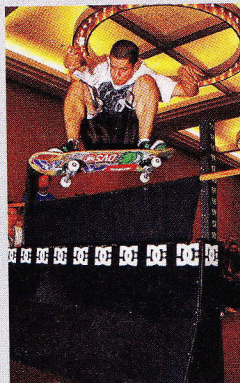
40 Create a mini golf course in your house, and get your entire family to play

Can you bank a ball off a wall, under the couch, and into a cup? Can you chip it through the doggie-door? Try setting up shoes and pans as obstacles. Use wrapping paper tubes for chutes and books as ramps. Once your golf course is finished, challenge your family to a putt-putt competition!



41 OLLIE OVER SOMETHING

Skateboarder Luis Tolentino, who tied the record for highest ollie (44½ inches), offers his advice for mastering the most fundamental trick in skating. But first put on a helmet!



1. PUSH YOUR BACK FOOT DOWN

Start the ollie by pushing your back foot down until the tail of your board hits the ground. Once the tail touches, start jumping toward where you want to land.

2. SLIDE YOUR FRONT FOOT FORWARD As you're jumping, drag your front foot toward the nose of the board to level out. This will help you clear your obstacle. Enjoy your air time!

3. PREPARE FOR LANDING As you descend, have your feet over the bolts of your deck. Bend your knees when you land to absorb the impact.

4. START SMALL When you're just beginning, try to ollie up onto a curb. As you progress, you can start stacking other skateboards. Eventually, you'll move up to ollieing trash cans!

42 START THE WAVE AT A SPORTING EVENT

43 Strike out a hitter in Wiffle ball Baffle hitters with Wiffle ball benders of all varieties.

- **Curveball** To throw the standard breaking ball, grip the ball along the seam. Put your index and middle fingers on top of the ball, with the slots facing to the left for righties and to the right for lefthanded throwers.

- **Screwball** The opposite of a curveball, this pitch will curve to the right for righties and to the left for lefties. Hold it like a curveball, but with the slots facing the opposite direction.

- **Riser** Throw it correctly, and the ball will curve up! With the slots facing down, grip the ball along the seam so that your fingers are on the side of the ball. Use a sidearm motion, give it a good spin, and watch the batter whiff.



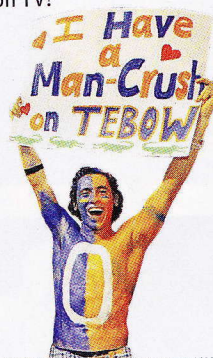
44

Go to a major league baseball game

There's nothing like a day at the park, where you can see the game's greatest players, enjoy stadium treats, and get a chance to catch a foul ball. It sure beats watching the game on TV. If your parents are up for a drive, plan a ballpark road trip this summer.

45 Make a ballpark sign

All you need is a poster board, a marker, and something to say. If you're in the bleachers, draw a bull's-eye and add HIT IT HERE. Keep your message short, and write it big for all to see. Remember to record the game at home too. Maybe you'll get on TV!



46 Say "good game" in a foreign language

With the World Cup under way and the Little League World Series just around the corner, learn how to say "good game" in other languages. Here are a few to start:

Spanish Buen juego (pronounced bwen hway-go)

Italian Bel gioco (pronounced bell joko)

German Gutes spiel (pronounced gootes shpeel)

Japanese Ee guy moo

47 Learn a fight song

Know where your favorite player went to college? Then show some spirit and sing the school fight song, loud and proud. Learn the words at FightSongLyrics.com. A timely serenade may even help you nab an autograph.



48 Ride a wave

If you don't have a board, give bodysurfing a go. The key, according to six-time world champion Tim Casinelli, is kicking as hard and quickly as you can. That will keep you in the wave without being pulled underwater.



49

STAY OFF THE COMPUTER

50 Solve a brain twister

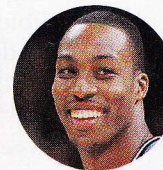
What do these three athletes have in common? (Answer on page 55)



TONY ROMO



DEREK JETER



DWIGHT HOWARD